

How do I get three real hours of work done a day?

Three hours of focused work that moves the business is a good day. Even a ten-hour day rarely gives you more than three or four. Clear the list with the four Ds and one test (would you want a CEO you paid \$150,000 a year doing this?), check email twice a day, keep one list, and put the week's priorities into the diary before the week starts: no more than three hours of above-the-line work a day, with 30 minutes of white space between blocks. Ten minutes saved a day is a working week a year.

Why does a full day in the office move the business so little?

<

How to get three real hours a day: the method, step by step

The method has seven steps: run the CEO test, sort with the four Ds, contain email, keep one list, allocate before the week, schedule it done, and protect the time.

1. **Run the CEO test on everything you do.** If you paid a CEO \$150,000 a year (or the equivalent in your currency) to run your company, would you be happy to see them jumping on an edit to save 300 bucks, or doing their own admin? Or would you want them on sales, marketing, business development and the cash flow forecast? Anything that fails the test goes into the next step.
2. **Sort every task into the four Ds.** Delete it, delegate it, defer it, or do it. Write your whole list into the four boxes below so the Do box gets the hours. If the delegate box fills up

3. **Give email two slots a day and touch each one once.** Email isn't instant messaging: it's someone making a request on your time. Check it at 1pm and 4pm, turn off every notification except texts, calendar and calls, and put the slots in your signature. Open an email only to deal with it, using one of three options. When I first did this I had 19,000 emails I hadn't looked at. If the backlog is out of control, select all and archive it: nothing is lost, and the inbox starts at zero (Inbox Zero is Merlin Mann's idea).

Copy and paste: the email signature line

To serve my clients better, I check my email at 1pm and 4pm. If your enquiry is urgent, call or text me on [number].

Copy and paste: the three options for every email

<

5. **Allocate before the week starts.** Take the three to five goals for the week (they come out of your quarterly priorities, which is what [planning your year](#) produces) and give each one a day before Monday arrives. Block out what's already fixed first: a shoot day, the prep the day before. Themed days help. When I taught this, mine ran Monday content, Tuesday calls and community, Wednesday and Thursday sales, Friday free.
6. **Schedule it done, with no more than three hours of above-the-line work a day.** Above-the-line work is strategic and deliberate: three calls with three clients, researching a company before tomorrow's meeting. Below the line is checking email, sending an invoice, anything that doesn't move you closer to the goal. Put each above-the-line task into the diary as a timed block, keep 30 minutes of white space between blocks because something always comes in sideways, and roll anything unfinished to the first block of the next day. Schedule Monday to Thursday and leave a spare day. Done looks like a diary that already holds the week's priorities on Monday morning.

Thursday, theme []: [time] to [time] [task]. 30 minutes white space. [time] to [time] [task]

Friday: spare day for anything that rolled.

Email: 1pm and 4pm only.

Other goals, personal, waiting on: []

Monthly actions: []

7. **Protect the time.** Systems will beat willpower every single time, so set it up: noise-cancelling headphones on, and "Could you give me an hour?" to anyone who wanders over. When something interrupts, unless someone is waiting on a thing you promised, ask whether it's a hell yes or a no. A firm but polite no saves you the pile of extra work that "I'll take a look at it" creates.

A worked example: my week of 26 November 2018

</

Day	Goals
Tuesday	Find an assistant for the London event. Finalise the landing page for the funnel.
Wednesday	Book in three new client strategy sessions. Research three branding experts.
Thursday	Record four weeks' worth of tips videos. Review the automation campaigns. Find a mindset coach for a webinar.
Friday	Complete a presentation.

Here's what a day with three blocks in the diary looks like, from an earlier Tuesday of mine (2016):

Time	Block
10:00 to 11:00	Shoot three rants (bumped from Monday, when the day ran away)
11:00 to 11:30	White space in case

The mistakes that undo it

The method fails in five ways.

- **Keeping a long list and calling it progress.** I used to tick off 45 of 60 things in a week and feel productive. The ticking is a dopamine hit. The question is whether any of the 45 moved me closer to a client.
- **Answering the email the moment it lands.** Speed of reply rarely means a good reply, especially when it's feedback on an edit and you're feeling it.
- **Doing the ten-minute job yourself because it's quick.** Hand it off and spend the ten minutes on a call to a lapsed client instead.
- **Treating "be fluid" as permission to put things off.** Moving a task when the day changes is fine. If the sales calls need making, they go in the diary and

- Every task you're carrying lives on one list.

Your one move this week

What's the one thing you can commit to implementing this week? If you're not sure, start here.

Before next Monday, write down next week's three to five goals and put each one into the diary as a timed block, with 30 minutes between blocks. Leave Friday clear for anything that rolls.

One thing executed every week creates 50 strategic moves a year.

Questions like these come up regularly on our weekly Elite Boardroom calls. If you